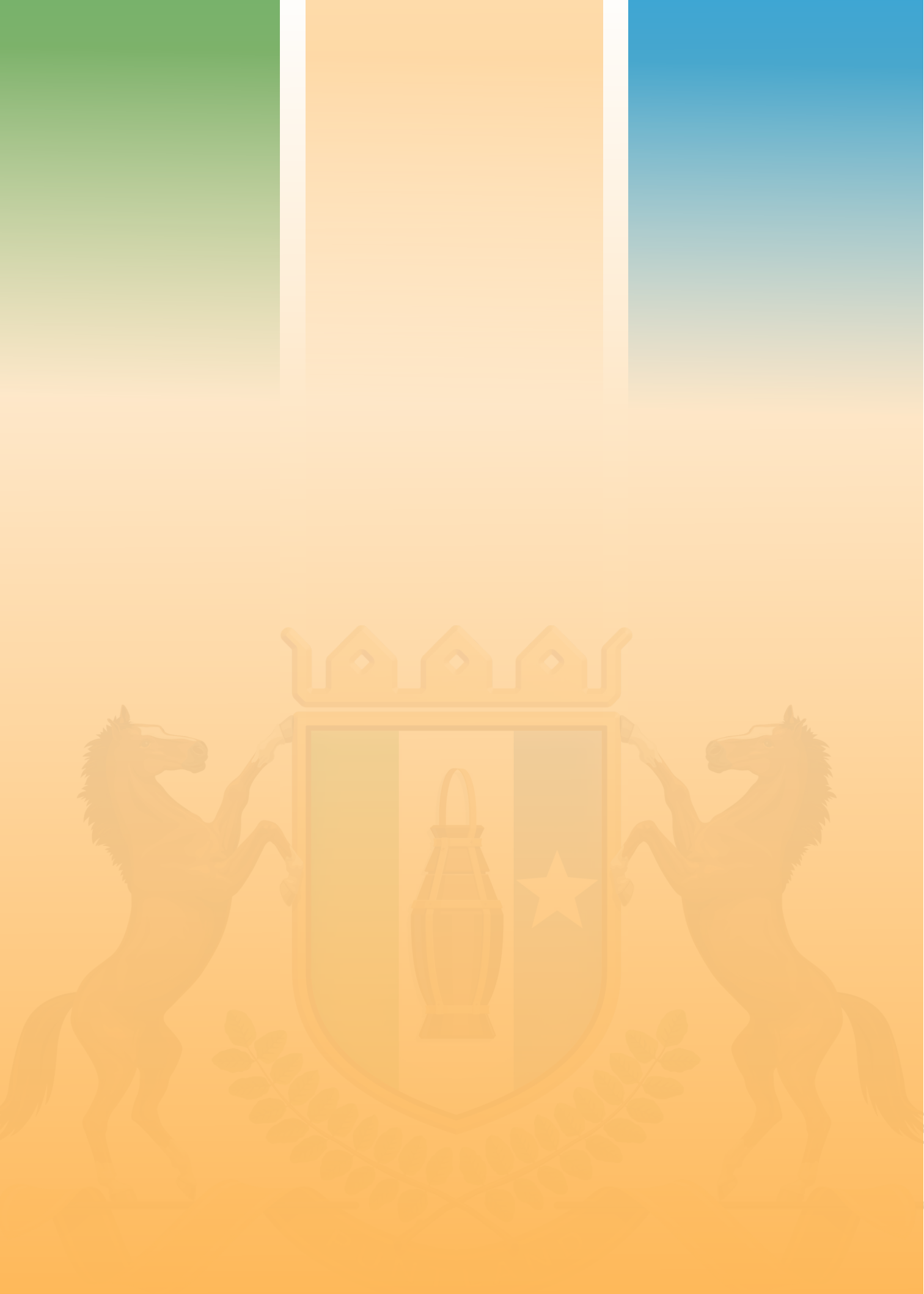




Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy (2025 - 2029)

Ministry of Interior, Federal Affairs,
and Democratisation (MoIFAD)







Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy (2025 - 2029)

Ministry of Interior, Federal Affairs,
and Democratisation (MoIFAD)

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Foreword

Social cohesion is the cornerstone of a peaceful, prosperous, and resilient society. It is the foundation upon which trust, cooperation, and shared identity are built, enabling communities to thrive even in the face of adversity.

In Puntland, we have long recognized the importance of fostering unity and inclusivity as essential elements of sustainable development. Today, as we face evolving challenges—from displacement and resource scarcity to clan-based tensions and economic disparities—the need for a comprehensive and inclusive approach to social cohesion has never been more urgent.

The *Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy* represents a bold and visionary step forward in our collective efforts to build a more united and resilient Puntland.

This strategy is not just a document; it is a roadmap for action, a call to collaboration, and a testament to our shared commitment to peace, stability, and prosperity for all. It reflects the voices of our people, the wisdom of our traditional leaders, and the dedication of our partners, all of whom have contributed to shaping this vision.

At the Ministry of Interior, Federal Affairs, and Democratization (MOIFAD), we are proud to lead this initiative, guided by the principles of inclusivity, transparency, and accountability. This strategy aligns with our broader goals of strengthening governance, promoting equitable development, and ensuring that every citizen—regardless of clan, gender, or displacement status—can contribute to and benefit from Puntland's progress.

The success of this strategy depends on the active participation of all stakeholders: government institutions, traditional and religious leaders, civil society organizations, international partners, the private sector, and, most importantly, our communities. Together, we must work to bridge divides, address historical grievances, and create an environment where every individual feels valued and empowered.



This strategy is not just a document; it is a roadmap for action, a call to collaboration, and a testament to our shared commitment to peace, stability, and prosperity for all. It reflects the voices of our people, the wisdom of our traditional leaders, and the dedication of our partners, all of whom have contributed to shaping this vision.

As we embark on this journey, I am reminded of the resilience and strength of the Puntland people. From our rich cultural heritage to our unwavering commitment to peace, we have the tools and the determination to overcome challenges and build a brighter future. This strategy is a testament to that spirit, and I am confident that, with your support, we will achieve our vision of a cohesive, inclusive, and prosperous Puntland.

I extend my deepest gratitude to all those who have contributed to the development of this strategy, including our partners, community leaders, and the dedicated team at MOIFAD. Let us move forward together, united in purpose and committed to action, for the benefit of current and future generations.

Together, we build a stronger Puntland.

Mohamed Ali Farah Farmayeri

Director General
Ministry of Interior, Federal Affairs, and Democratization
Puntland State of Somalia
17th April 2025

Acknowledgements

Ministry of Interior, Federal Affairs, and Democratisation (MoIFAD) expresses its deepest appreciation to all those who contributed to the development of the Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy (2025–2029).

We wish to acknowledge the leadership and guidance of **H.E. Abdi Farah Saed**, Minister of Interior, and the strategic oversight provided by **H.E. Mohamed Ali** Farah Farmayeri, Director General of MoIFAD, whose commitment to inclusive governance and durable solutions has been central to this process.

MoIFAD extends sincere thanks to the donors of the programme i.e., the Norwegian Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the Swiss Agency for Development and Cooperation (SDC), and the Netherlands Enterprise Agency (RVO), for their generous financial support and steadfast commitment to social cohesion and inclusive development in Somalia.

We appreciate the invaluable contributions of our implementing partners, IOM, UN-Habitat, and UNDP, for their technical assistance, strategic guidance, and partnership throughout this process.

This strategy would not have been possible without the active engagement of community stakeholders, including traditional and religious leaders, civil society representatives, women and youth groups, and members of Displacement-Affected Communities (DACs), who generously shared their experiences, perspectives, and aspirations during consultations and fieldwork.

Finally, we commend the dedicated efforts of the technical research and drafting team from Acumen Research Solutions, whose coordination of the assessment, consultations, and strategy development was instrumental to this outcome.

Together, we have shaped a roadmap for a more inclusive, resilient, and peaceful Puntland.

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List of Abbreviations and Acronyms

CSO	Civil Society Organization
DAC	Displacement Affected Community
FCDO	Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office
FGD	Focus Group Discussion
FGS	Federal Government of Somalia
FMS	Federal Member State
HLP	Housing, Land and Property
IDP	Internally Displaced Person
INGO	International Non-Governmental Organisation
IOM	International Organisation for Migration
KII	Key Informant Interview
KPI	Key Performance Indicator
M&E	Monitoring and Evaluation
MELR	Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Reporting
MHPSS	Mental Health and Psychosocial Support
MoIFAD	Ministry of Interior, Federal Affairs, and Democratisation (Puntland)
MoPEDIC	Ministry of Planning and International Cooperation (Puntland)

NDSCP	National Displacement Social Cohesion Policy
NGO	Non-Governmental Organisation
NRC	Norwegian Refugee Council
PDRC	Puntland Development Research Centre
PPP	Public-Private Partnership
PSCS	Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy
RVO	Rijksdienst voor Ondernemend Nederland (Netherlands Enterprise Agency)
SDC	Swiss Agency for Development and Cooperation
SWOT	Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Threats
TDR	Traditional Dispute Resolution
TVET	Technical and Vocational Education and Training
UN-Habitat	United Nations Human Settlements Programme
UNDP	United Nations Development Programme
USAID	United States Agency for International Development
WoGA	Whole-of-Government Approach

Executive Summary

The *Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy (PSCS) 2025–2029* provides a strategic roadmap for fostering inclusive governance, sustainable peace, and resilient communities across Puntland State. Developed through a participatory and evidence-driven process, the strategy responds to the complex interplay of displacement, urbanization, environmental stress, and socio-political fragmentation that has weakened cohesion in both urban and rural areas.

Purpose and Rationale

At the heart of the strategy is the need to rebuild trust among communities and between citizens and state institutions. Findings from the 2024 Formative Assessment revealed key drivers of social tension and exclusion, including:

- Protracted displacement and insecure housing
- Inequitable access to land and basic services
- Clan-based governance and political exclusion
- Discrimination against IDPs, women, youth, and minority groups
- Limited mental health and psychosocial support (MHPSS)
- Environmental degradation and climate-induced shocks

While these challenges are significant, Puntland's evolving governance landscape, including the rollout of "One Person, One Vote" electoral reforms, presents a critical opportunity to enhance civic trust, promote accountability, and build a shared vision for peace.

Strategic Objectives and Pillars

The strategy is anchored in five interdependent strategic objectives:

1. Strengthen Inclusive Governance and Social Accountability

Enhance the legitimacy and responsiveness of formal and traditional institutions, promoting participation across all social groups.

2. Promote Social Integration and Community Cohesion

Support reconciliation, shared identity, and psychosocial healing through inclusive platforms and community-based dialogue.

3. Ensure Equitable Access to Services and Resources

Address disparities in land, housing, education, and healthcare access, particularly in displacement-affected urban areas.

4. Promote Inclusive and Effective Conflict Prevention and Dispute Resolution

Integrate traditional and formal mediation mechanisms while ensuring inclusivity in peacebuilding processes.

5. Institutionalize Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Reporting (MELR)

Establish a harmonized MELR system to inform implementation, ensure accountability, and foster adaptive learning.

Implementation Framework

The PSCS will be delivered in three interlinked phases:

Short-Term (0–12 months): Coordination structures, quick-impact interventions, MHPSS pilots, and MELR setup.

Medium-Term (1–3 years): Policy reforms, civic platforms, land titling, and peace committee expansion.

Long-Term (3–5 years): Urban planning integration, public-private partnerships, and institutionalization of cohesion measures.

Stakeholder Coordination and Sustainability

The Ministry of Interior, Federal Affairs and Democratization (MoIFAD) will lead implementation, supported by sectoral ministries, district authorities, CSOs, traditional leaders, and development partners. A multi-level coordination framework, resource mobilization strategy, digital governance tools, and risk mitigation measures are included to ensure sustainability and institutional ownership.

The Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy lays the foundation for a more peaceful, just, and inclusive Puntland. Through collaborative action and continuous learning, it empowers communities and institutions to address the root causes of social fragmentation and build a unified society where all individuals, regardless of displacement status, clan, gender, or identity, can thrive.

Chapter One

Introduction



1.1. Strategic Overview

The *Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy (2025–2029)* is a government-led roadmap designed to strengthen inclusive governance, community resilience, and peaceful coexistence across Puntland State. Developed through a consultative and evidence-based process, the strategy responds to the complex challenges caused by prolonged displacement, rapid urbanisation, social inequality, and climate-induced shocks.

Puntland has made important gains in regional governance and state-building over the past two decades. However, widespread displacement, land-related disputes, and unequal access to services continue to undermine social cohesion and stability, particularly in urban centres such as Bosaso, Garowe, and Galkayo. IDPs, returnees, and other vulnerable groups face persistent marginalisation, while local governance systems often operate in parallel with traditional authorities without adequate coordination.

The Social Cohesion Strategy seeks to address these intersecting issues by establishing a framework for inclusive and accountable governance, equitable service

delivery, economic participation, and sustainable peacebuilding. It recognises the importance of both horizontal social cohesion - relationships between diverse groups in society - and vertical cohesion-relationships between citizens and state institutions.

This strategy draws from and complements key federal and state policies, including the *National Displacement and Social Cohesion Policy*, the *National Durable Solutions Strategy (2020–2024)*, the *National Solutions Pathways Action Plan (2024–2029)*, and *Puntland's Vision 2030*. It also aligns with global commitments such as the *UN Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement*, the *IASC Framework on Durable Solutions for IDPs*, and the *UN Secretary-General's Action Agenda on Internal Displacement (2022)*.

At its core, the Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy promotes a “*One Community*” vision—one that transcends social divisions and recognises the equal rights of all individuals, regardless of clan affiliation, displacement status, gender, or origin. It provides a platform for community co-creation, government leadership, and international partnerships to work together in delivering durable solutions and long-term peace.



The Social Cohesion Strategy seeks to address these intersecting issues by establishing a framework for inclusive and accountable governance, equitable service delivery, economic participation, and sustainable peacebuilding. It recognises the importance of both horizontal social cohesion - relationships between diverse groups in society - and vertical cohesion- relationships between citizens and state institutions.

1.2. Key Definitions

To ensure clarity and consistency, the strategy applies the following official and widely recognised definitions:

Table 1: *Definition of key terms*

TERM	DEFINITION
Social Cohesion	The strength of relationships and the sense of solidarity among members of a society. Social cohesion fosters trust, cooperation, and peaceful coexistence, enabling individuals and groups to work together for the common good.
Horizontal Cohesion	Trust and cooperation between individuals and groups within society (e.g. across clans, genders, generations, or IDP/host communities).
Vertical Cohesion	Trust and accountability between citizens and governing institutions at national, regional, and local levels.
Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs)	"Persons or groups of persons who have been forced or obliged to flee or to leave their homes or places of habitual residence... and who have not crossed an internationally recognized state border." (<i>UN Guiding Principles, 1998</i>)
Durable Solutions	A durable solution is achieved when IDPs no longer have specific needs linked to displacement and can enjoy their rights without discrimination. Durable solutions can be: 1) return, 2) local integration, or 3) settlement elsewhere in the country (<i>IASC Framework, 2010</i>)
Participatory Governance	Decision-making processes that include citizens—particularly vulnerable groups—in the design, implementation, and monitoring of public policies and services.
Traditional Dispute Resolution (TDR)	Customary practices and norms used by traditional leaders (xeer-beegti, Ismida, religious authorities) to mediate and resolve conflicts at the community level.
Mental Health and Psychosocial Support (MHPSS)	A spectrum of services that support the emotional, psychological, and social wellbeing of individuals affected by displacement, trauma, or conflict.
One Person, One Vote	A principle of democratic participation being introduced in Puntland to enhance representation, accountability, and vertical social cohesion.
Displacement-Affected Communities (DACs)	Populations, including IDPs, returnees, and host communities—who are directly impacted by the effects of displacement.
Do No Harm	A principle that ensures interventions avoid exacerbating existing tensions or inequalities within a society.

1.3. Background

Puntland, a semi-autonomous Federal Member State (FMS) of Somalia, has made notable strides in governance, reconciliation, and public administration. Despite this progress, the region continues to grapple with complex and overlapping challenges that strain its social fabric, ranging from protracted displacement and rapid urbanisation to land disputes, limited institutional capacity, and social exclusion.

As of early 2024, Puntland hosts one of the highest concentrations of IDPs in Somalia, primarily in urban centres such as Bosaso, Galkacyo, and Garowe. Many IDPs have fled conflict, drought, and floods, arriving in overcrowded informal settlements with limited access to land, services, and livelihood opportunities. This influx has placed immense pressure on urban infrastructure and created tensions between displaced groups and host communities, particularly around housing, land, and basic services.

At the same time, Puntland's governance landscape is shaped by a hybrid system that blends state institutions with traditional

authority structures, including clan elders and religious leaders. While this dual system offers local legitimacy, it often lacks coordination and consistency, especially in conflict resolution, resource allocation, and service delivery. Moreover, traditional governance structures frequently exclude women, youth, minority clans, and other marginalised populations from participation in public affairs.

The persistent gap between formal and informal governance systems, coupled with limited social accountability mechanisms, has contributed to growing public distrust and weakened vertical cohesion. Meanwhile, economic inequality, youth unemployment, and underrepresentation in decision-making continue to undermine horizontal cohesion, exacerbating social fragmentation.

These dynamics call for an integrated strategy, one that bridges institutional divides, centres community priorities, and supports durable solutions for displacement-affected populations.



Puntland's governance landscape is shaped by a hybrid system that blends state institutions with traditional authority structures, including clan elders and religious leaders. While this dual system offers local legitimacy, it often lacks coordination and consistency, especially in conflict resolution, resource allocation, and service delivery.

1.4. Strategy Rationale

The Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy emerges as a timely response to the region's growing need for a coordinated, inclusive, and durable approach to social cohesion.

A range of assessments, including the *Puntland Social Cohesion Formative Assessment (2024)* and displacement-focused evaluations, have identified systemic barriers to integration and peaceful coexistence in Puntland. These include:

- **Displacement and housing insecurity**, with many IDPs living in informal settlements under threat of eviction.
- **Land tenure disputes** between clans, urban authorities, and IDPs, often escalating into conflict.
- **Fragmented service delivery**, with public services concentrated in central areas and often inaccessible to displacement-affected populations.
- **Low levels of participation** by women, youth, minority clans, and IDPs in governance, economic decision-making, and peace processes.
- **Limited trust in institutions**, fuelled by inconsistent service delivery, weak accountability, and clan-based governance structures.
- **Environmental degradation and climate shocks**, which intensify displacement and exacerbate competition over scarce resources.

Despite these challenges, Puntland's evolving governance frameworks and its commitment to democratic reforms, including the rollout of "*One Person, One Vote*", present a strong foundation for rebuilding trust, enhancing participation, and fostering unity across diverse communities.

This strategy is designed to operationalise the *National Displacement and Social Cohesion Policy in Puntland* by providing a context-specific roadmap that promotes:

- Hybrid governance and local legitimacy
- Equitable access to services and land
- Integrated urban planning and housing security
- Conflict-sensitive approaches and community-based mediation
- Economic and social inclusion of vulnerable groups
- Community co-creation and shared accountability

In doing so, the strategy offers a platform for durable solutions, not only for IDPs and returnees, but also for host communities and broader society, ensuring that all residents, regardless of origin or background, can participate in building a peaceful and inclusive Puntland.

1.5. Strategic Vision and Objectives

Strategic Vision



A socially cohesive, politically integrated, and economically inclusive Puntland where displaced persons, returnees, host communities, and other vulnerable groups coexist peacefully, enjoy equitable access to resources, and contribute meaningfully to society.

This vision recognises Puntland's diverse population and unique governance context. It is grounded in principles of inclusion, participation, and resilience, with the goal of addressing root causes of social fragmentation and fostering long-term peace.

Strategic Objectives

To realise its vision of a socially cohesive, politically integrated, and economically inclusive Puntland, this strategy outlines five interdependent strategic objectives.

Each objective corresponds to a thematic pillar and is informed by evidence from the formative assessment, stakeholder consultations, and alignment with national and global policy frameworks.

Together, they form the foundation for coordinated action, inclusive governance, and long-term peacebuilding across Puntland.



Strategic Objective 1: Strengthen Inclusive Governance and Social Accountability

This objective seeks to promote a “*One Community*” approach that recognises all residents, whether host, IDP, returnee, or minority, as equal citizens entitled to participate in governance and access services. It aims to:

- Expand participatory and inclusive governance systems that integrate traditional and formal institutions.
- Build trust between citizens and authorities by strengthening civic dialogue and transparency.
- Ensure marginalised groups, including DACs, women, youth, and minority groups including, persons with disability (PWDs), are actively represented in public decision-making.

Asociallycohesive,politicallyintegrated,andeconomically inclusive Puntland where displaced persons, returnees, host communities, and other vulnerable groups coexist peacefully, enjoy equitable access to resources, and contribute meaningfully to society.

This objective is operationalised through **Pillar 1: Inclusive Governance and Civic Participation.**



Strategic Objective 2: Promote Social Integration and Community Cohesion

This objective responds to the deepening social divides caused by prolonged displacement, marginalisation, and resource competition. It aims to:

- Foster mutual trust, shared identity, and respect among all social groups through community dialogue, cultural interaction, and inclusive platforms.
- Support social healing and reconciliation by embedding MHPSS into education, peacebuilding, and youth engagement.
- Empower women, youth, and minority groups as active agents in cohesion-building processes.

This objective is operationalised through **Pillar 2: Social Integration and Community Cohesion.**

Strategic Objective 3: Ensure Equitable Access to Services, Land, and Livelihood Opportunities

Addressing unequal access to public services and secure land tenure is central to reducing grievances and social fragmentation. This objective aims to:

- Improve access to essential services, particularly for IDPs and vulnerable groups, in urban and peri-urban areas.
- Promote land and shelter security through accessible documentation, legal support, and urban planning.
- Expand livelihoods and economic opportunities through skills training, inclusive business support, and resource-sharing mechanisms.

This objective is operationalised through **Pillar 3: Equitable Access to Services and Resources.**



Strategic Objective 4: Promote Inclusive and Effective Conflict Prevention and Dispute Resolution

To build lasting peace, this objective strengthens conflict resolution systems that are inclusive, locally anchored, and responsive. It aims to:

- Integrate traditional, religious, and formal mechanisms into a cohesive framework that resolves disputes justly and equitably.
- Support early warning and rapid response systems to prevent the escalation of local tensions.
- Ensure women, youth, and minorities are meaningfully involved in peacebuilding and mediation.

This objective is operationalised through **Pillar 4: Conflict Prevention and Dispute Resolution.**





Strategic Objective 5: Institutionalise Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Reporting (MELR)

To ensure adaptive, accountable, and evidence-informed implementation, this objective focuses on establishing a strong MELR system. It aims to:

- Develop a harmonised MELR framework aligned with national tools such as the Durable Solutions Progress Survey (DSPS).
- Promote inclusive tracking mechanisms that reflect the voices and realities of DACs and other vulnerable groups.
- Strengthen institutional capacity for learning, data management, and transparency through regular reviews and knowledge-sharing.

This objective is operationalised through **Pillar 5: Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Reporting (MELR)**.

1.6. Key Thematic Areas

The strategy is structured around five thematic pillars, each corresponding to a strategic objective. These pillars form the backbone of implementation and serve as entry points for coordinated interventions.

Pillar 1: Inclusive Governance and Civic Participation

- Enhance the integration of traditional and formal governance structures.
- Institutionalise participatory planning, civic forums, and community scorecards.
- Support Puntland's ongoing electoral reforms (One Person, One Vote) as a pathway for social accountability.

Pillar 2: Social Integration and Cohesion

- Promote community dialogues, inter-group trust-building, and collaborative initiatives.
- Facilitate cultural exchanges, inclusive media, and joint service access.
- Mainstream MHPSS into education, peacebuilding, and livelihoods.

Pillar 3: Equitable Access to Services and Resources

- Expand WASH, education, and healthcare in underserved urban and peri-urban areas.
- Formalise land tenure through coordinated titling, especially for IDPs.
- Encourage shared infrastructure use between IDPs and host communities.

Pillar 4: Conflict Prevention and Dispute Resolution

- Establish hybrid peace committees with women and youth representation.
- Train elders and legal professionals in inclusive mediation and conflict sensitivity.
- Launch local early warning platforms tied to community leadership and local authorities.

Pillar 5: Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Reporting (MELR)

- Develop a results framework aligned with FMS and federal systems.
- Use the DSPS tool to track perceptions of inclusion, belonging, and safety.
- Promote evidence-based programming and public reporting of progress.

1.7. Approach and Guiding Principles

The Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy was developed through a participatory and inclusive process grounded in local realities, evidence, and collaborative visioning. Rather than being an externally imposed policy, the strategy reflects the aspirations, concerns, and commitments of the people of Puntland, especially those most affected by displacement, exclusion, and marginalisation.

The strategy was shaped by:

- A formative assessment that involved key informant interviews (KIIs), focus group discussions (FGDs), and community consultations with IDPs, host communities, returnees, traditional leaders, women, youth, civil society, and government institutions.
- A comprehensive policy review of global, national, and subnational frameworks relevant to social cohesion, protection, and durable solutions.

Validation workshop was held on 17th April 2025 in Garowe to ensure the strategy was aligned with local priorities and strengthened institutional ownership. Comments and feedback gathered during the workshop were incorporated into the final draft to enhance its relevance and applicability.

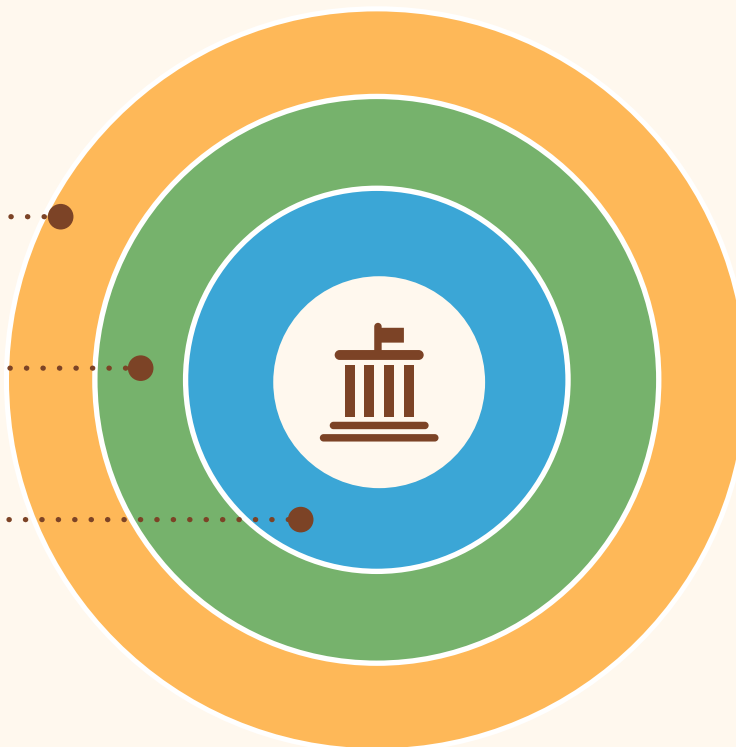
The implementation of the strategy will be guided by the following principles:

WHOLE-OF-GOVERNMENT (WOGA) APPROACH

Local Government

Regional Government

National Government



1.8. Whole-of-Government (WoGA) Approach

MoIFAD will lead implementation, with active coordination across key ministries (Planning, Education, Health, Justice, etc.), district governments, and municipalities. This approach ensures consistency, sustainability, and institutional integration across state systems.

i. Whole-of-Society Inclusion

All actors i.e., government, CSOs, traditional leaders, religious leaders, private sector, academia, international partners, and community members, will be meaningfully engaged in strategy implementation, monitoring, and refinement.

ii. Community Co-Creation

Communities, particularly displacement-affected populations and marginalised groups will co-design and co-lead interventions. This promotes ownership, local legitimacy, and effectiveness.

iii. Equity and Social Justice

All people in Puntland, regardless of clan, gender, age, or origin, must have equal rights and opportunities. Special attention will be given to uplifting IDPs, returnees, women, youth, minority clans, and persons with disabilities.

iv. Conflict Sensitivity and Do-No-Harm

All interventions will be designed and implemented in ways that reduce tensions, build trust, and avoid reinforcing existing grievances. This includes inclusive beneficiary targeting, participatory planning, and transparency.

v. Durable Solutions Orientation

The strategy aligns with the IASC Framework on Durable Solutions for IDPs, promoting local integration, secure land tenure, and long-term inclusion of displacement-affected communities.

vi. Resilience and Adaptive Management

The strategy will remain flexible to evolving risks, contexts, and community feedback. An integrated monitoring, evaluation, and learning system will ensure data-driven decision-making and adaptive programming.

vii. Transparency and Accountability

All stakeholders, including community members, will have access to information about progress, budgets, and results. Mechanisms for citizen feedback, complaints handling, and social accountability will be built into implementation.



The Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy was developed through a participatory and inclusive process grounded in local realities, evidence, and collaborative visioning. Rather than being an externally imposed policy, the strategy reflects the aspirations, concerns, and commitments of the people of Puntland, especially those most affected by displacement, exclusion, and marginalisation.

1.9. Alignment with Legal and Policy Frameworks

The development of the Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy was informed by an extensive review of national and international legal and policy instruments. This review provided critical insights and benchmarks that ensured the strategy aligns with both global standards and local realities. Drawing on lessons from Somalia and other countries in the region, the strategy integrates principles of social justice, displacement protection, community resilience, and inclusive governance.

The legal and policy documents reviewed span across governance levels, from global frameworks to Puntland's own subnational laws and development plans. These sources provide normative guidance, institutional roles, and programmatic priorities relevant to social cohesion, displacement-affected populations, land governance, and durable solutions.

Puntland's Social Cohesion Strategy also reflects and builds upon best practices and frameworks from across the Horn of Africa and beyond, including Kenya, Rwanda, Uganda, South Africa, and Zimbabwe—countries that have developed progressive social cohesion, reconciliation, or unity frameworks following political or social transitions.

Table 2: Relevant policies and frameworks reviewed for Strategy Development

GOVERNANCE LEVEL	KEY LEGAL AND POLICY DOCUMENTS
Global	— UN Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement (1998) — IASC Framework on Durable Solutions for IDPs (2010) — UN Secretary-General's Action Agenda on Internal Displacement (2022) — Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)
Regional	— African Union Convention for the Protection and Assistance of Internally Displaced Persons in Africa (Kampala Convention) — Nairobi Declaration on Durable Solutions for Somali Refugees and Returnees
Federal (Somalia)	— Provisional Constitution of the Federal Republic of Somalia — National Durable Solutions Strategy (2020–2024) — National Solutions Pathways Action Plan (2024–2029) — National Policy on Refugee Returnees and IDPs — National Social Cohesion and Displacement-Affected Areas Policy (2021–2025) — National Evictions Guidelines (2019) — Somalia National Transformation Plan (NTP)

GOVERNANCE LEVEL	KEY LEGAL AND POLICY DOCUMENTS
State (Puntland)	— Puntland Vision 2030 — Puntland Policy Guidelines on Displacement/Guidelines for IDP land management No. 05/2019 (available) — Land dispute tribunal regulation (requires minister's assent) — Puntland Urban Land Management Law (ULML)/Urban Land Management Act No.1 of Aug 25, 2020 — Puntland Local Government Law Puntland IDP Policy (Revised 2022) — Puntland Local Integration Strategy 2024-2027 — Decentralization Policy (2023-2030) — Puntland Municipal Planning and Land Regulations
District/Sub-District	— Urban development and planning tools from Bosaso, Garowe, and Galkayo municipalities — Bosaso City Strategy and Urban Extension Plan — Bosaso District Community Action Plan (CAP) — IDP settlement mapping and land regularisation documents (e.g. Saameynta Joint Programme tools)

This strategy is not developed in isolation; it is embedded in a broader architecture of governance, humanitarian, development, and peacebuilding initiatives across Somalia. In addition to policy documents, it also aligns with active programming led by key actors, including UN agencies (IOM, UN-Habitat, UNDP), federal ministries, and civil society platforms engaged in durable solutions and social cohesion initiatives.

By grounding the strategy in these frameworks, Puntland aims to ensure:

- Consistency with national laws and constitutional commitments
- Reinforcement of durable solutions as both a legal obligation and a policy priority
- Harmonisation with district-level planning tools and municipal strategies
- Legitimacy and alignment with international norms for displacement protection, human rights, and inclusion

Chapter Two

Situational Analysis



2.1. Context Overview

Puntland faces layered and interdependent challenges that affect its social cohesion landscape. While relatively stable compared to other parts of the country, the region is affected by long-standing political fragmentation, displacement-driven urbanization, environmental stress, and socio-economic exclusion.

A holistic analysis reveals that social cohesion is strained by structural inequalities, identity-based marginalization, clan politics, and insufficient coordination across governance levels. At the same time, Puntland presents unique opportunities, such as strong traditional governance systems, an emerging digital governance agenda, and youth-led peacebuilding, that can be leveraged to build more inclusive and cohesive communities.

The situational analysis presented below outlines the core factors shaping social cohesion in Puntland, with a specific focus on the interplay between displacement, governance, conflict, and economic resilience.

2.2. PESTEL Interdependencies Analysis

The following PESTEL analysis identifies the Political, Economic, Social, Technological, Environmental, and Legal dynamics shaping the implementation environment for this strategy, emphasizing the interlinkages between these dimensions.

Table 3: *PESTEL analysis*

KEY DRIVERS	INTERDEPENDENCIES AND IMPACT ON SOCIAL COHESION
Political	
— Clan-based political structures — Decentralized governance and limited institutional capacity — One-person-one-vote pilot reforms	— Clan politics directly influence service delivery, land allocation, and representation, often excluding marginalized groups. — Political instability can exacerbate conflict over resources. — Electoral reforms offer a key opportunity to improve vertical accountability and inclusivity.
Economic	
— Youth unemployment — Livelihood loss due to displacement — Informal economy and limited market access	— Economic exclusion, especially among IDPs, increases vulnerability and fuels tension. — Weak private sector support in DACs limits opportunity for recovery. Economic inclusion is critical for conflict prevention.

KEY DRIVERS		INTERDEPENDENCIES AND IMPACT ON SOCIAL COHESION	
Social			
— IDP-host community divides — Gender inequality — Social norms restricting inclusion		— Inequity in access to services and civic life contributes to marginalization. — Cultural and clan-based norms often limit women's and youth participation in governance. — Cohesion requires tackling stigma and identity-based exclusion.	
Technological			
— Digital governance rollouts — Unequal internet access in rural areas		— E-governance can promote transparency but risks reinforcing exclusion if digital divides are not addressed. — Technology offers scalable tools for citizen engagement and feedback loops.	
Environmental			
— Recurring droughts and floods — Rapid urbanization — Competition over land and water		— Resource scarcity, exacerbated by climate change, is a key trigger of displacement, land disputes, and tension. — Environmental stressors reinforce urban overcrowding and weaken institutional responses.	
Legal			
— Weak land tenure systems — Plural legal frameworks (Sharia, xeer, statutory) — Limited IDP protection mechanisms		— Legal fragmentation hampers access to justice and formal land ownership. — Informal dispute systems often exclude women and youth. — Harmonizing legal systems is essential for accountability and stability.	

2.3. Urban vs. Rural Dynamics in Social Cohesion

Social cohesion in Puntland is shaped differently in urban and rural contexts:

Urban Settings (such as Bosaso, Garowe): Rapid growth due to displacement has led to informal settlements, competition over services, and higher exposure to urban land disputes. Urban areas show higher reliance on formal institutions but face challenges with congestion, governance capacity, and land tenure insecurity.

Rural Settings: In rural areas, traditional governance remains dominant. There are fewer services, but stronger social bonds and inter-clan systems exist. However, droughts and insecurity have weakened traditional systems and displaced rural populations into urban centres.

The strategy recognizes that tailored interventions are needed to address the specific cohesion challenges and assets in both settings.

2.4. Displacement and Mixed Migration Dynamics

Puntland hosts many IDPs, returnees, and refugees, many of whom have moved due to armed conflict, environmental stress (especially drought), and cross-border economic migration via the Eastern Route. These mixed migration flows present challenges for service delivery, identity registration, and protection.

- **IDPs** face discrimination, insecure tenure, and lack of access to education, health, and livelihoods.
- **Returnees and migrants** often lack reintegration support, adding pressure to overstretched urban systems.
- **Host communities** feel marginalized by international and state programs focused on IDPs.

This strategy aims to bridge the divide between displaced and host populations by fostering a “One Community” approach that dissolves artificial binaries in public service access and rights.

2.5. Mental Health and Psychosocial Support (MHPSS)

Psychosocial distress remains a silent but significant barrier to cohesion. Trauma, violence, and displacement affect community trust, civic participation, and reconciliation. MHPSS services are scarce, particularly in rural areas and IDP settlements. The strategy promotes the integration of MHPSS within education, youth programming, and peacebuilding structures to address root causes of exclusion and build resilience.

2.6. SWOT Analysis

Table 4: *SWOT analysis*

KEY FACTORS		IMPLICATIONS FOR STRATEGY	
Strengths			
— Strong traditional conflict resolution institutions — National frameworks (e.g., NDSCP, Durable Solutions) — Engagement from development partners — Youth-led peacebuilding and cultural in urban settings e.g., Puntland Arts and Culture Week		— Leverage traditional leaders in inclusive ways. — Align with national and partner-led initiatives. — Invest in youth.	
Weaknesses			
— Coordination gaps between institutions — Gender and youth underrepresentation — Limited MELR infrastructure — High dependency on external funding		— Build cross-sector platforms. — Introduce inclusive planning models. — Develop local MEL systems.	
Opportunities			
— Digital tools for civic participation e.g. UNDP’s Consul platform, mobile audio-visual units (MAVU) by PDRC — One-person-one-vote electoral reform — Private sector engagement — MHPSS–livelihood integration		— Use civic tech for feedback loops; link MELR to DSPS. — Scale community-driven microenterprises and psychosocial support.	
Threats			
— Political instability and electoral delays — Clan tensions and resource disputes — Climate shocks — International funding volatility		— Introduce risk mitigation plans. — Foster inter-clan mediation platforms. — Institutionalize local funding channels.	

2.7. From Analysis to Action: Linking Insights to Strategy Pillars

The findings above directly inform the five strategic objectives of this strategy:

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE	INFORMED BY
Inclusive Governance and Accountability	Political exclusion, weak civic participation, siloed institutions
Social Integration and Cohesion	Displacement-based stigma, inter-clan divisions, lack of inclusive cultural spaces
Equitable Access to Services and Resources	Disparities in infrastructure, legal land insecurity, urban overcrowding
Conflict Prevention and Dispute Resolution	Informal vs. formal justice gaps, inter-clan conflict, exclusion of youth/women
Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Reporting (MELR)	Lack of centralized tracking, donor dependence, absence of feedback loops

2.8. Stakeholder Power-Interest Mapping

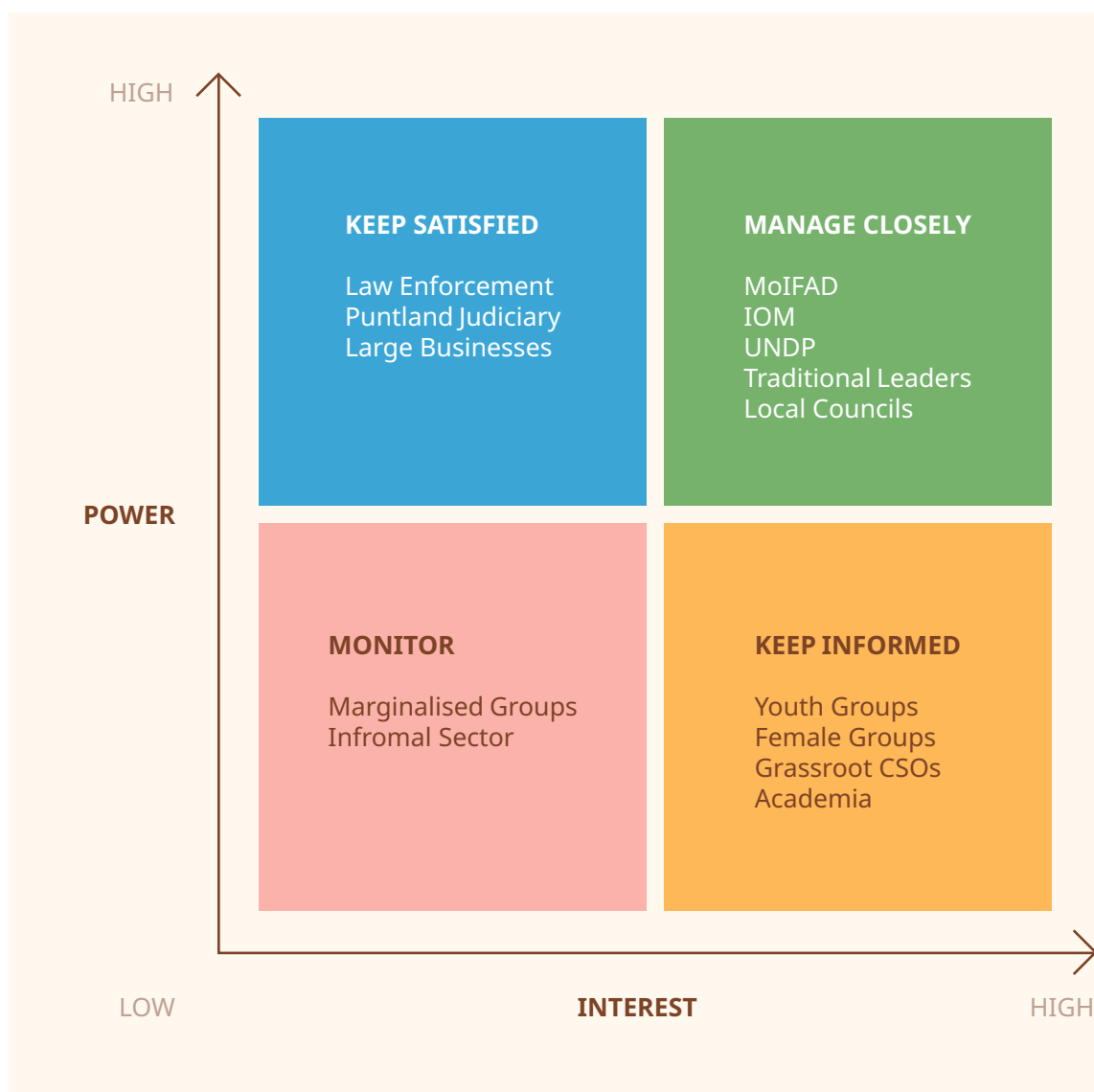
Effective implementation of the Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy hinges on a clear understanding of the diverse stakeholders involved, their levels of influence, and their interest in promoting social cohesion. To that end, a **Power-Interest Grid** has been developed to visually map stakeholder groups and guide tailored engagement strategies.

This mapping classifies stakeholders based on two key dimensions:

- **Power** – their ability to influence decision-making, resource allocation, and implementation processes.
- **Interest** – the degree of concern or stake they hold in the successful implementation of social cohesion initiatives

The grid helps identify how to engage each stakeholder group effectively:

Figure 2: Visual representation of stakeholder power-interest grid



High Power, High Interest (Manage Closely):

Includes key government institutions (e.g., MoIFAD, Local Councils), major UN agencies (e.g., IOM, UNDP), and traditional leaders. These actors are central to coordination, resource mobilisation, and policy alignment. They must be regularly consulted and involved in core decision-making.

High Power, Low Interest (Keep Satisfied):

Stakeholders such as law enforcement, judiciary, or larger businesses may not be fully engaged but hold significant influence. Targeted advocacy can help align their objectives with the strategy.



Effective implementation of the Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy hinges on a clear understanding of the diverse stakeholders involved, their levels of influence, and their interest in promoting social cohesion. To that end, a **Power-Interest Grid** has been developed to visually map stakeholder groups and guide tailored engagement strategies.



Low Power, High Interest (Keep Informed):

Includes youth and women's groups, grassroots CSOs, academia, and DAC representatives. Though they may have limited formal influence, their involvement is essential for community buy-in and legitimacy.

Low Power, Low Interest (Monitor):

These are actors with peripheral roles or low visibility in social cohesion efforts. They should be kept informed and encouraged to participate through awareness and outreach efforts. This mapping supports targeted engagement, inclusive participation, and ensures resources and efforts are invested where they can yield the greatest strategic impact.

Chapter Three

Thematic Pillars of the Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy

3.1. Thematic Pillars Overview

This chapter outlines the five interrelated thematic pillars of the *Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy*. These pillars were developed through an inclusive consultative process informed by the findings of the *Formative Assessment*, which included engagements with government institutions, traditional leaders, IDP representatives, CSOs, and community members in Bosaso and Garowe.

The pillars reflect local needs and opportunities while aligning with national and regional priorities for durable solutions and inclusive governance. Each pillar combines narrative context with clear strategic intent and examples of activities that will guide implementation.

Figure 3: *PSCS five pillars*



3.2. Pillar 1: Inclusive Governance and Civic Participation



Objective 1:

Promote Inclusive Political and Economic Integration for All Residents in Displacement-Affected Communities

This objective aims to dismantle binary distinctions between “IDPs” and “host communities” by fostering a “One Community” identity. All residents, regardless of social background or displacement history, should be seen and treated as equal citizens with rights to political, economic, and social participation.

The approach calls for the promotion of civic belonging, shared accountability, and equitable access to services and resources. It targets IDPs, returnees, marginalized clans, women, and youth who are traditionally underrepresented in formal decision-making structures and often excluded from economic participation.



Outcome 1:

Economically and politically integrated and socially cohesive communities in displacement-affected areas wherein all citizens feel that they are respected, included, and empowered

Outcome Indicators

- % of profiled marginalized and vulnerable groups effectively participating in political decision-making processes
- % of DACs benefiting from local economic and capacity-building initiatives using skills gained
- % of DACs possessing valid shelter or land documents

Table 5: *Pillar 1 outputs and indicators*

OUTPUT	INDICATOR	MEANS OF VERIFICATION
Output 1.1 DACs, marginalized and vulnerable groups have established social, economic, and political ties and are accessing equitable services	# of DAC and vulnerable groups with access to equitable services aligned to their expressed needs	— Service delivery reports — Project implementation records — Community scorecard
Output 1.2 DACs and marginalized individuals are capacitated to engage in self-help, employment, and livelihoods	# of DAC using skills gained to launch self-help or livelihood initiatives in their communities	— Training attendance sheets — Business registration docs — Beneficiary interviews
Output 1.3 Legal support and documentation services are provided to DACs to strengthen land and shelter tenure security	% of targeted DAC households receiving valid land or shelter documentation because of project-supported interventions	— HLP documentation logs — Legal clinic service reports — Community feedback

Priorities for Implementation

- **Expand inclusive services** in displacement-affected areas to cover both IDPs and host communities.
- **Participatory profiling of skills and capacities** held by IDPs to inform local economic planning.
- **Promote awareness of available employment and livelihood opportunities** for all residents.
- **Mobilize resources for cash transfers and voucher systems** targeting both vulnerable host and displaced groups.
- **Provide access to Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET)** for youth and women across community lines.
- **Foster enabling environments for small businesses** run by both IDPs and host community members.
- **Facilitate joint livelihood initiatives and economic collaborations** between different social groups to promote trust and integration.
- **Support land and shelter documentation drives** targeting displacement-affected households, including legal clinics and mobile help desks to facilitate access to HLP services.
- **Raise awareness and build capacity on land rights and documentation processes** through community forums, information campaigns, and collaboration with traditional and legal institutions.

3.3. Pillar 2: Social Integration and Community Cohesion



Objective 2:

Strengthen Social Integration and Community Cohesion through Shared Identity, Inclusion, and Mutual Respect

The long-standing impact of displacement, marginalization, and rapid urbanization in Puntland has fractured traditional community structures and social trust. Tensions between IDPs and host communities have been fuelled by resource competition, unequal access to opportunities, and a lack of inclusive spaces for dialogue and joint action.

This objective seeks to restore and reinforce community ties by promoting social inclusion, cultural interaction, and solidarity across lines of clan, gender, age, and displacement status. It also emphasizes psychosocial healing, collective identity, and active participation in shared community life.

The Strategy recognizes the need to address isolation, exclusion, and barriers to integration faced by IDPs, marginalized clans, women, and youth across Puntland. Interventions will prioritize community awareness campaigns, inclusive cultural and sports activities, and the establishment of social platforms for dialogue and mutual support.

Particular attention will be given to promoting integrated settlements, ensuring equitable access to education and livelihoods, and addressing gatekeeping behaviours that restrict participation.

Localized stakeholder mapping and conflict sensitivity assessments will guide all interventions. Peace dialogues, community-driven mediation committees, and strengthened grievance redress mechanisms will be key instruments to foster peaceful coexistence and resilience at the community level.”



Outcome 2:

Communities in displacement-affected areas demonstrate mutual trust, shared identity, and inclusive social networks that bridge historical divisions

Outcome Indicators

- % of IDPs and host community members reporting improved social cohesion and trust
- % of DACs actively participating in joint community activities and networks
- % of women, youth, and minority groups reporting inclusion in community dialogues and initiatives

Table 6: Pillar 2 outputs and indicators

OUTPUT	INDICATOR	MEANS OF VERIFICATION
Output 2.1 Diverse community platforms and inclusive initiatives implemented to strengthen cohesion	# of inter-group events held (dialogues, festivals, joint forums) in displacement-affected areas	— Event reports and attendance sheets — Photos/videos of the events — Post-event evaluations
Output 2.2 Communities receive support for psychosocial wellbeing and trauma healing	# of MHPSS programs delivered and number of participants reached	— MHPSS program records — Beneficiary tracking sheets — Partner implementation reports — Pre/post well-being assessments
Output 2.3 Youth, women, and marginalized groups are actively engaged in social and peacebuilding structures	# of community committees with active and equitable representation of youth, women, and minorities	— Gender disaggregated community membership lists — Minutes — Partner reports

Priorities for Implementation

- **Conduct community forums and dialogues** that bring together IDPs, returnees, and host populations to address shared concerns and build consensus.
- **Organize cultural exchange activities** (e.g. festivals, storytelling, intergenerational forums) to foster unity and respect for diversity.
- **Establish safe spaces and peer support networks** for women and youth to promote belonging and emotional healing.
- **Strengthen local peacebuilding committees** with inclusive membership to support reconciliation at community level.
- **Integrate MHPSS into schools and community centres** to address trauma and social fragmentation.
- **Promote inter-clan and inter-community sports or livelihood groups** to encourage organic cooperation and relationship-building.

Informed by stakeholder validation feedback, the Strategy further commits to:

- Supporting integrated planning of settlements and services for both IDPs and host communities.
- Promoting cultural integration through social cohesion events and awareness initiatives.
- Embedding community participation in the design and monitoring of programs.
- Addressing vulnerabilities through expanded MHPSS access and inclusive governance structures.
- Establishing village-level mediation committees to pre-empt and resolve local conflicts.



This objective seeks to restore and reinforce community ties by promoting social inclusion, cultural interaction, and solidarity across lines of clan, gender, age, and displacement status. It also emphasizes psychosocial healing, collective identity, and active participation in shared community life.

3.4. Pillar 3: Equitable Access to Services and Resources



Objective 3:

Enhance Equitable Access to Services and Promote Inclusive Management of Land, Water, and Livelihood Resources

Inequitable access to public services and basic infrastructure remains a key driver of grievance, exclusion, and inter-group tension in Puntland. IDP settlements face systemic barriers in securing adequate housing, water, education, healthcare, and secure land tenure.

This objective addresses disparities in service delivery by promoting inclusive planning processes, equitable distribution of resources, and community engagement in infrastructure decision-making. It also calls for collaborative mechanisms to manage land, water, and public services in a way that recognizes both IDP and host community needs.



Outcome 3:

Displacement-affected and marginalized communities access quality public services and participate in transparent and inclusive resource planning and management.

Outcome Indicators

- % increase in IDP and marginalized household access to health, education, housing, and WASH services
- % of public infrastructure projects incorporating community inputs from diverse groups
- % of land registration cases successfully processed for vulnerable households
- % of IDP households with formal land ownership or tenure security

Table 7: *Pillar 3 outputs and indicators*

OUTPUT	INDICATOR	MEANS OF VERIFICATION
Output 3.1 Public services expanded or adapted to reach underserved and displacement-affected communities	# of new or upgraded service delivery points (clinics, water points, schools) in targeted settlements	— Infrastructure completion certificates — Site visit reports with geo-tagged photos — Ministry or local authority service expansion reports — Community validation surveys
Output 3.2 Land tenure and documentation processes extended to vulnerable households	# of IDP and vulnerable households with legal land documentation secured	— Land registry or cadastral office records — Copies of land certificates or documentation — Beneficiary lists — Reports from land registration campaigns
Output 3.3 Inclusive infrastructure and service planning processes institutionalized	# of planning forums with participation of women, IDPs, youth, and minority clan representatives	— Forum participation records disaggregated by demographics — Meeting minutes — Community consultation reports — Partner monitoring reports

Priorities for Implementation

- **Support legal land registration processes** for IDPs and other vulnerable groups to ensure security and reduce land-based conflict.
- **Expand mobile and temporary infrastructure** (e.g. clinics, classrooms, WASH facilities) in high-density informal settlements.
- **Conduct service mapping and needs assessments** in IDP-hosting areas to guide equitable investment.
- **Establish inclusive public infrastructure planning committees** that reflect the diversity of the local population.
- **Facilitate community-government dialogues** on fair water access, land use, and public spending.
- **Promote equitable WASH interventions** that reduce resource strain and inter-group competition.

3.5. Pillar 4: Conflict Prevention and Dispute Resolution



Objective 4:

Promote Inclusive and Effective Conflict Prevention and Dispute Resolution in Displacement-Affected Areas

In Puntland, persistent inter-clan tensions, land and political disputes, and competition over scarce resources continue to challenge peace and stability. Traditional mechanisms for resolving conflict, such as the Xeer and the role of elders, are still widely used but often exclude youth, women, and other marginalized groups.

This objective supports the development of inclusive and hybrid approaches that integrate traditional, formal, and religious systems to resolve disputes. It emphasizes the participation of all community members, especially those traditionally excluded, and the establishment of early warning and rapid response systems to address emerging conflicts before they escalate.



Outcome 4:

Communities are equipped with inclusive and responsive mechanisms to prevent, mitigate, and resolve conflicts through integrated local systems

Outcome Indicators

- % of community disputes resolved through inclusive, locally recognized mechanisms
- % of community members reporting reduced inter-group tensions (land, political, resource-based)
- % of DACs perceiving low risk of eviction or land-related violence (DSP-aligned)

Table 8: Pillar 4 outputs and indicators

OUTPUT	INDICATOR	MEANS OF VERIFICATION
Output 4.1 Community-based peacebuilding and mediation structures are inclusive and functional	# of peace committees/ mediation networks with active participation of women and youth	— Committee member lists disaggregated by age and gender — Meeting minutes or activity logs — Partner progress reports — Community feedback surveys
Output 4.2 Early warning and conflict response systems are established and operational	# of alerts or conflict signals addressed through early response mechanisms	— Early warning system activation logs — Conflict response case records — District peace and security committee reports — Monitoring visit reports
Output 4.3 Traditional and formal actors are capacitated to resolve disputes based on human rights and inclusive norms	# of elders, religious leaders, and local officials trained in inclusive dispute resolution methods	— Training attendance registers — pre-and post-training assessments — Training reports — Certificates of participation

Priorities for Implementation

- **Support inclusive community peace structures**, ensuring representation of youth, women, minority clans, and displacement-affected groups.
- **Train traditional, religious, and formal leaders** on conflict-sensitive, rights-based approaches to dispute resolution that align with national frameworks.
- **Establish community early warning and rapid response mechanisms**, including integration with local admin and district peace and security committees.
- **Conduct participatory conflict mapping and dialogue forums**, especially in areas with land and political tension.
- **Facilitate peer learning exchanges** between regions or districts with successful hybrid mediation models.

3.6. Pillar 5: Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Reporting (MELR)



Objective 5:

Institutionalize Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Reporting (MELR) Systems for Adaptive and Inclusive Strategy Implementation

A strong MELR system is critical for ensuring the Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy remains relevant, responsive, and results driven. Currently, the absence of integrated tracking tools and feedback loops limits the ability of government institutions and partners to learn from implementation, identify gaps, and adjust programming in real time.

This objective aims to establish a coordinated MELR framework led by MoIFAD, aligned with national tools such as the DSPS, and linked to decentralized data collection systems. It also emphasizes the importance of transparency, regular reporting, and stakeholder engagement to foster accountability and mutual learning.



Outcome 5:

MoIFAD and partners use integrated and inclusive MELR systems to monitor strategy implementation, inform decisions, and share lessons

Outcome Indicators

- % of strategic outcomes tracked using real-time or periodic data tools
- # of review sessions held per year with community, government, and partner participation
- % of strategy indicators aligned with national frameworks (e.g. DSPS)

Table 9: Pillar 5 outputs and indicators

OUTPUT	INDICATOR	MEANS OF VERIFICATION
Output 5.1 A harmonized MEL framework is developed and adopted by MoIFAD and key partners	MEL plan approved and integrated into MoIFAD systems	— Approved MEL framework document — Official endorsement letters or circulars — Integration into MoIFAD workplans and reporting templates
Output 5.2 Strategy implementation is regularly reviewed and adapted based on evidence	# of quarterly or annual reviews conducted with stakeholder input	— Review workshop reports — Attendance sheets and meeting minutes — Updated implementation plans and action points
Output 5.3 Data systems and learning platforms are strengthened to promote knowledge sharing	# of MEL training sessions conducted # of learning briefs produced and shared	— Training reports and attendance records — Copies of learning briefs and knowledge products — MEL platform usage statistics or log

Priorities for Implementation

- **Develop a unified MELR plan** aligned with national tools like the DSPS survey, , and Saamaynta MEL frameworks.
- **Conduct baseline, midline, and endline assessments** to measure progress across all five strategic objectives.
- **Hold periodic strategy review meetings**, including MoIFAD, district officials, CSOs, DAC representatives, and donors.
- **Train MEL officers and focal points at central and district levels** to use digital tools and participatory data collection methods.
- **Create community feedback loops**, such as citizen scorecards, radio polls, or mobile feedback apps to gather beneficiary perspectives.
- **Document and share lessons learned, best practices, and strategy updates** through accessible formats (briefs, visuals, community forums).

Chapter Four

Implementation and Coordination Framework

4.1. Chapter Overview

The successful rollout of the *Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy (PSCS)* depends on an inclusive, phased, and coordinated implementation framework that brings together government, civil society, development partners, and community stakeholders. This chapter outlines mechanisms for stakeholder coordination, a phased action plan by pillar, resource mobilization, risk mitigation, validation, digital governance, and sustainability, all anchored in the five strategic objectives.

4.2. Leadership and Stakeholder Coordination

The MoIFAD will lead the implementation of the PSCS, coordinating inter-ministerial and multi-stakeholder engagement. MoIFAD will host a dedicated *Social Cohesion Steering Committee* to provide strategic oversight, supported by thematic working groups and regional coordination units.

Key ministries such as MoPEDIC, Ministry of Justice, Ministry of Health, Ministry of Education, and Ministry of Women and Family Affairs will implement pillar-specific interventions.

District authorities will operationalize strategy components locally, while civil society, traditional leaders, UN agencies, academia, and the private sector will contribute through technical expertise, funding, and community mobilization.

MoIFAD will serve as the Secretariat of the Strategy and anchor the MELR framework.



Key ministries such as MoPEDIC, Ministry of Justice, Ministry of Health, Ministry of Education, and Ministry of Women and Family Affairs will implement pillar-specific interventions. District authorities will operationalize strategy components locally, while civil society, traditional leaders, UN agencies, academia, and the private sector will contribute through technical expertise, funding, and community mobilization. MoIFAD will serve as the Secretariat of the Strategy and anchor the MELR framework.

Table 10: *Stakeholder engagement matrix*

STAKEHOLDER	ROLE & RESPONSIBILITIES	ENGAGEMENT APPROACH
MoIFAD (Lead)	— Lead coordination and oversight of strategy implementation — Ensure inter-ministerial alignment and ownership — Monitor progress and ensure timelines are respected — Mobilize and coordinate resources and partners	Inter-ministerial steering committee, technical working groups, progress review forums
Line Ministries MoPEDIC, Health, Education, Women & Family Affairs	— Integrate social cohesion objectives into sectoral policies — Implement pillar-specific interventions (such as education, health access, land tenure) — Align sector budgets with strategy priorities	Sector-specific coordination platforms, policy dialogues, joint workplans
District & Local Governments	— Localize the strategy through district development plans — Facilitate service delivery and citizen engagement — Maintain updated data and feedback from communities	District social cohesion committees, ward-level consultations, service delivery reviews
Civil Society Organizations & INGOs	— Deliver programs aligned to cohesion objectives — Strengthen social networks, solidarity, and trust — Mobilize community participation across clan, gender, and age groups	Community forums, co-implementation of projects, inclusive mobilization campaigns
Traditional & Religious Leaders Isimada, Xeer-beegti Ulama	— Mediate disputes and promote peaceful coexistence — Use religious and cultural platforms to promote tolerance — Mobilize community support for cohesion actions	Local mediation forums, inter-clan dialogues, mosque/faith-based outreach
Displacement-Affected Communities (DAC) Representatives	— Represent IDP and returnee voices in planning — Mobilize DAC participation in programs and policy dialogue — Provide feedback on needs, access, and social barriers	Community assemblies, participatory assessments, IDP councils

STAKEHOLDER	ROLE & RESPONSIBILITIES	ENGAGEMENT APPROACH
Department of Human Protection & Refugees / Durable Solutions Units	— Coordinate rights protection, registration, and profiling — Regulate partner activities in IDP settings — Support equitable access to services	Technical coordination with MoIFAD, joint monitoring visits, data sharing mechanisms
Private Sector & Chamber of Commerce	— Support economic inclusion and training for vulnerable groups — Contribute to infrastructure and shared community services — Engage in public-private partnerships for social impact	PPPs, inclusive hiring practices, co-investment in health and education
Academic & Research Institutions PSU, East Africa University	— Generate evidence and local knowledge on cohesion — Contribute to M&E, MEL learning, and capacity-building — Pilot innovations and social cohesion curricula	Research partnerships, knowledge-sharing forums, youth training hubs



4.2. Phased Action Plan by Thematic Pillar

The strategy will be implemented in three interlinked phases: Short-Term (0–12 months), Medium-Term (1–3 years), and Long-Term (3–5 years). Each phase is aligned to the five strategic objectives and thematic pillars, ensuring that actions are sequenced, feasible, and impact-driven.

Table 11: *Phased Action Plan by Thematic Pillar*

PILLAR	SHORT-TERM	MEDIUM- TERM	LONG-TERM
Pillar 1 Inclusive Governance	Key Action Establish coordination structures; train officials	Key Action Launch civic forums, digital feedback tools	Key Action Integrate cohesion into reforms
	Expected Outcomes Stakeholder alignment and ownership	Expected Outcomes Improved accountability	Expected Outcomes Inclusive governance institutionalized
Pillar 2 Social Integration	Key Action Conduct IDP-host dialogues, MHPSS pilots	Key Action Set up community centres, inter- clan forums	Key Action Embed cohesion into education & media
	Expected Outcomes Foundations for trust and healing	Expected Outcomes Strengthened inter-group solidarity	Expected Outcomes Cultural shift toward unity
Pillar 3 Equitable Services	Key Action Map needs; deploy mobile clinics/schools	Key Action Begin land titling and WASH upgrades	Key Action Finalize inclusive urban plans
	Expected Outcomes Quick gains in underserved areas	Expected Outcomes Secure land access; better service delivery	Expected Outcomes Equity and dignity in public services
Pillar 4 Conflict Resolution	Key Action Train elders, religious leaders, youth in mediation	Key Action Operationalize early warning systems	Key Action Formalize hybrid justice mechanisms
	Expected Outcomes Local peace actors capacitated	Expected Outcomes Local conflict response activated	Expected Outcomes Coherent dispute resolution system
Pillar 5 MELR	Key Action Establish MEL system; align with DSPS	Key Action Midline evaluation, adaptive programming	Key Action Final evaluation and national learning
	Expected Outcomes Baseline data established	Expected Outcomes Evidence-driven learning	Expected Outcomes Strategy scaled and sustained

4.3. Validation and Capacity Building

Stakeholder validation and capacity development will be sustained throughout implementation. Activities will target technical gaps, strengthen governance systems, and foster learning.

Table 12: *Validation and capacity building*

ACTIVITY	OBJECTIVE	TARGET GROUP
Validation Workshop	Incorporate feedback and revise implementation	MoIFAD, line ministries, DAC reps
Capacity Building Trainings	Equip stakeholders with technical tools	Local officials, CSOs, youth leaders
Technical Assistance	Embed MEL, DRR, gender, and inclusion in delivery	MEL focal points, sector experts
Peer Learning Exchanges	Share successful local models	Districts, traditional leaders, CSOs

4.4. Resource Mobilization

A blended financing strategy will ensure sustainability, reduce reliance on external aid, and foster local ownership.

Table 13: *Resource mobilization sources and approaches*

FUNDING SOURCE	APPROACH
Government Allocations	Advocate for social cohesion line items in annual budgets
Donor Engagement	Align strategy with SDC, EU, UN, USAID, FCDO priorities
Public-Private Partnerships	Infrastructure, skills training, shared social facilities
Community Contributions	Co-financing, cooperative models, zakat-based initiatives
Innovative Finance	Diaspora remittances, impact bonds, micro-grants

4.5. Risk Mitigation Framework

Table 14: Risk mitigation framework

ACTIVITY	OBJECTIVE	TARGET GROUP
Political instability	Implementation delays	Embed strategy into decentralised frameworks
Donor uncertainty	Funding gaps	Pool funding; local budget absorption
Social resistance	Undermines trust	Prioritize community participation, local messaging
Institutional gaps	Weak delivery	Capacity building, technical support
Climate shocks	Disrupt services, drive displacement	Mainstream DRR and resilience planning

4.6. Leveraging Digital Governance

Digital solutions will increase accountability, efficiency, and real-time feedback mechanisms

Table 15: Digital governance tools

DIGITAL TOOL	PURPOSE
MEL Dashboards	Track indicators, visualize progress
E-feedback Platforms	Crowdsource citizen input and grievances
Blockchain Pilots	Transparent land records and service access
E-learning Platforms	Reach remote stakeholders with training
SMS/USSD Surveys	Gather community insights on cohesion

4.7. Sustainability and Exit Strategy

The strategy embeds long-term measures for local ownership, government absorption, and donor alignment.

Table 16: Sustainability and exit strategy Mechanism

MECHANISM	GOAL	ACTION
Community Ownership	Local champions drive activities	Social cohesion councils, IDP- host coalitions
Institutionalization	Embed in national/state policy frameworks	Legal integration, budget lines
Knowledge Management	Preserve lessons and scale	Digital repository, policy briefs, south-south learning
Donor Transition	Minimize dependency	Results-based co-financing, cost- sharing frameworks

Annexes



Annex 1: Implementation Work Plan – Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy (2025–2029)

This implementation framework outlines priority actions under each strategic objective, phased bi-annually over the 5-year period.

STRATEGIC OUTCOME	KEY PRIORITY INTERVENTIONS	YEAR 1	YEAR 2	YEAR 3	YEAR 4	YEAR 5
Outcome 1: Inclusive governance and civic participation	Establish One-Community platforms integrating IDPs and host community representatives					
	Civic education on rights, responsibilities, and participatory governance					
	Facilitate training for local councils on social accountability tools					
	Expand civil society-government policy dialogues					
Outcome 2: Strengthened social integration and shared identity	Organize inter-clan and IDP-host community dialogues					
	Support cultural festivals, storytelling circles, and youth exchanges					
	Scale MHPSS programming within schools and community centres					
	Build safe spaces for women, youth, and minority participation					

STRATEGIC OUTCOME	KEY PRIORITY INTERVENTIONS	YEAR 1	YEAR 2	YEAR 3	YEAR 4	YEAR 5
Outcome 3: Equitable access to services and resources	Map and upgrade WASH, health, and education services in informal settlements					
	Launch mobile documentation drives for HLP and ID credentials					
	Establish inclusive planning committees at district level					
Outcome 4: Inclusive and hybrid conflict resolution	Form youth peace councils and women-led mediation networks					
	Conduct legal awareness campaigns and dispute mediation trainings					
	Operationalize community early warning and rapid response systems					
Outcome 5: Institutionalized MELR	Develop unified MEL framework aligned with DSPS tools					
	Conduct baseline, midline, and endline assessments					
	Host annual review meetings with government and community stakeholders					

Annex 2: Implementation Work Plan (2025–2029)

A summary implementation framework is provided below, showing priority activities for each strategic pillar over five years. The plan follows a phased approach aligned with the strategy's thematic areas.

KEY ACTIVITIES	2025 H1	2025 H2	2026 H1	2026 H2	2027 H1	2027 H2	2028 H1	2028 H2	2029 H1	2029 H2
Pillar 1: Inclusive governance and civic participation										
Establish district-level social cohesion coordination committees										
Conduct civic education forums and promote one person–one vote pilot initiatives										
Build capacity of local leaders in participatory governance										
Pillar 2: Social Integration and Community Cohesion										
Organize inter-group cultural exchanges and festivals										
Establish youth and women-led dialogue forums										
Integrate MHPSS into community and school programs										
Pillar 3: Equitable Access to Services and Resources										
Conduct service mapping and infrastructure needs assessments										
Expand mobile health, education, and WASH services in underserved areas										

KEY ACTIVITIES	2025 H1	2025 H2	2026 H1	2026 H2	2027 H1	2027 H2	2028 H1	2028 H2	2029 H1	2029 H2
Pillar 4: Conflict Prevention and Dispute Resolution										
Support legal land registration and tenure documentation for IDPs										
Train elders, clerics, and officials on inclusive dispute resolution										
Establish early warning systems and community peace structures										
Pillar 5: Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Reporting (MELR)										
Facilitate inter-district peer learning and conflict mapping										
Develop MELR system aligned to DSPS and MoIFAD indicators										
Conduct baseline, midline, and endline assessments										
Hold annual review and learning events with stakeholders										
Note: H1 = First Half; H2 = Second Half of the year										

Annex 3. Barriers to Social Cohesion and Solutions¹

BARRIERS IDENTIFIED	PROPOSED SOLUTIONS
Isolation due to peripheral IDP settlement locations limiting access to services	Promote integrated settlements and co-location of services for IDPs and host communities
Lack of inclusivity in social activities and program design	Organize joint cultural, sports, and dialogue events; ensure gender and minority representation in planning
Vulnerability due to lack of MHPSS support and social platforms	Establish community social platforms and strengthen MHPSS programming at local levels
Cultural and regional differences fuelling mistrust	Facilitate intercultural dialogues and awareness campaigns to promote mutual understanding
Inequitable access to education, livelihoods, and basic services	Expand education initiatives and create inclusive livelihood opportunities targeting marginalized groups
Gatekeeping by local actors restricting IDP participation in programs	Increase community awareness, advocacy for rights-based participation, and reduce gatekeeping influence
Apathy towards formal education among IDPs	Implement community sensitization on education benefits and integrate education access into cohesion initiatives
Lack of community participation during planning stages	Institutionalize participatory planning processes at the district and settlement level
Weak local grievance redress mechanisms	Establish village-level mediation committees and strengthen existing community-based dispute resolution systems
¹ Group work outcomes from the Puntland Social Cohesion Strategy ToT Training and Validation Workshop (14th -17th April 2025), facilitated by MoIFAD and Acumen Research.	

Annex 3. Validation Workshop Photos



Photo 1: Group photo



Photo 2: MOIFAD DG, Mr. Mohamed Ali Farah, speaks during the validation workshop



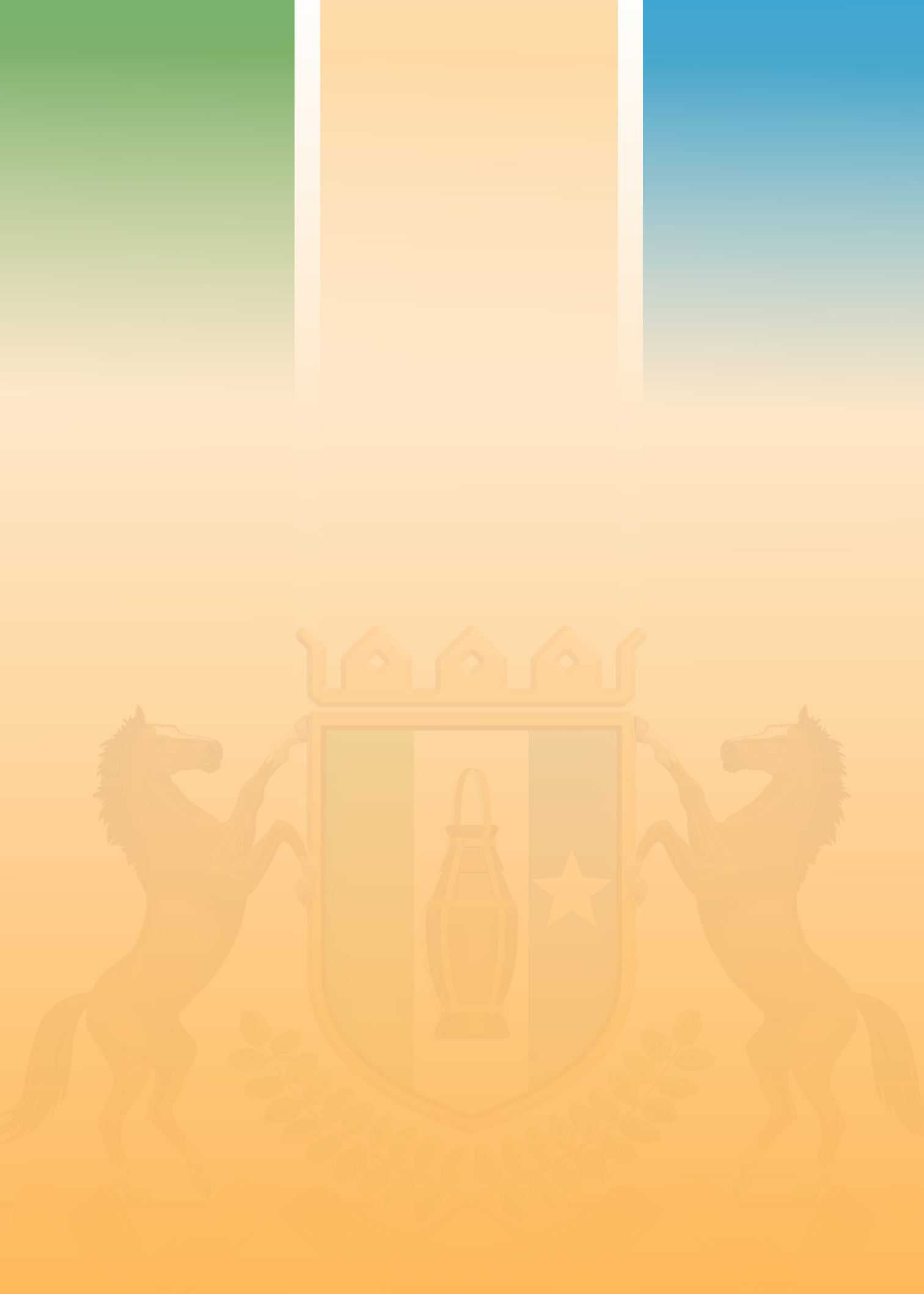
Photo 3: Validation workshop participants follow proceedings



Photo 4: Rufaa Ahmed from Acumen Research presents the draft strategy during the validation workshop

Annex 4. Partners and Programmes in Puntland

PARTNER OR AGENCY	PROGRAMMES OR PROJECTS	RELEVANCE TO SOCIAL COHESION AND DURABLE SOLUTIONS
UNDP	— Joint Programme on Local Governance (JPLG) — Rule of Law Programme	Supports inclusive governance, decentralisation, and access to justice
UN-Habitat	— Saameynta Programme — Urban Planning — Land Tenure Security Initiatives	Promotes land regularisation, inclusive city planning, and housing for IDPs
IOM	— Community Stabilisation Programme — Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM) — Saameynta	Addresses durable solutions, community cohesion, and displacement profiling
UNHCR	— Protection and Shelter for IDPs — Housing, Land and Property Rights	Supports IDP rights, security of tenure, and peaceful co-existence
NRC	— Legal Aid, Education, and Shelter Programmes	Enhances protection and legal inclusion for IDPs and vulnerable groups
Save the Children	— Child Protection, Education, and Livelihoods	Targets youth inclusion, family resilience, and education for peace
GIZ	— Peacebuilding, Vocational Training and Economic Resilience	Fosters youth engagement, skills development, and inclusive governance
EU	— Reconciliation and Governance Programmes	Supports state-building, civic engagement and peace processes
CARE	— Livelihoods and Women's Empowerment	Supports women-led cooperatives and economic inclusion





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